Free painting – intuition

When we paint freely, with no goal and no effort to make a pretty picture, we often reach for silver when we want **a soft shine**, or when we need **a little distance**. We do not always know why, though. Sometimes we know exactly, other times not at all. Both are fine.

What may be hiding behind a silver stroke

The same silver line on paper can mean **something completely different every time**, depending on what is going on in us at the moment. That is why there is no point in reading a painting like a test with a single correct answer.

Calm.

Soft silver areas and broad strokes. A colour that calms.

Night.

Silver on a dark ground. The moon, water, a gleam.

Distance.

A thin line that separates. Silence between two things.

Elegance.

A delicate, clean stroke. Pleasure in the fact that there is order.

Sadness.

A muted silver over livelier places. Something that cannot yet be shown.

Joy in shine.

The pure taste of metal and light. No hidden meaning.

Silver in a painting. Can it express what is happening inside?

Yes, **it can**, but **it does not have to**. A silver stroke is not automatically a message about coldness or aloofness. It can mean calm, the moon, elegance, distance and simple joy in shine. The amount of silver alone does not determine your state. That holds even when a child uses it.

While working you do not have to decide what exactly it means. Notice the hand, the pressure and whether you want to go on. Meaning comes only in connection with **your experience**.

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I want it on the canvas, but I don't dare put it on myself

A painting and a dress ask two completely different things of you. Silver in a painting can be quiet and beautiful, and still you do not feel like wearing a silver coat. Or the other way round. A silver mirror and silver earrings do not exclude each other.

Imagine the same silver on three women. On a woman with grey hair, on a singer and on a teenage girl. With the first you say “natural”, with the second “stage”, with the third “what is going on?”. **The colour has not changed. Your expectations have.**

A silver wardrobe is not automatically a sign of coldness or distance. First of all it is the wardrobe of a particular woman.

When silver takes over the space

First let the hand work. **Silver does not have to cover anything.** If you are afraid it will cool everything, try it first on a small paper or hold a silver cut-out against the painting. You will see the change without having to make it permanent right away.

Three things worth noticing

- **SHAPE**

  A line, an area, or glitter?

  A thin silver line can connect or separate something. A large area can create calm as well as coolness. While working you do not have to decide what exactly it means. Only later can you ask whether the stroke meant relief, distance or just pleasure in shine.

- **WEIGHT**

  Light, or cold?

  If the silver feels pleasantly light, leave it alone for a while and watch its shape. If an area is too cold, add a warm accent or a matt layer. If everything is glossy, add a difference of surface, direction of strokes or lightness.

- **COURAGE**

  You do not have to fill the whole surface at once

  Courage in painting does not mean you have to intervene in everything at once. If you want a gentle accent, try one line or a small circle. If you keep covering the previous layers, notice the feeling of covering itself. The interpretation can wait.

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What to take from the picture

It does not matter how the silver stroke looks. What matters is what you feel while making it and what is happening in your life at that moment. **Two identical paintings can have a completely different meaning.** One came from a feeling of calm, the other after a day when you wanted to withdraw. That is why you will not find a dictionary here, but **questions**.

A picture can speak even after time

Perhaps later you will connect the painting with a period when you needed to calm down. Perhaps with a decision that gave you perspective. Or you will keep seeing in it mainly a beautiful shine. In self-reflection inspired by art therapy what counts is the connection of the painting, your experience and a specific period of life. Silver by itself does not know your story.

Answers often do not come right away

Sometimes you look at what you have painted and it tells you nothing. In a week, a month or a year, though, it may suddenly dawn on you. That is fine. **The painting will wait until you are ready to understand it.**

If very strong or painful feelings appear while painting, do not stay alone with them. Talk about them with someone close or with a therapist. This page does not replace professional care.

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